For Japan, this distrust has been abetted by its fraught attempts to deal with the legacy of the Second World War and the sense on the part of most Asian nations that it has not sufficiently apologized for its wartime aggression and atrocities. Yet Japan's long-standing pacifist constitution and limited military presence in Asia after 1945 helped tamp down suspicions of its intentions. Since the 1970s, Tokyo has prioritized building ties with Southeast Asia, though until recently those were primarily focused on trade.

Since returning to power in 2012, Prime Minister Abe has moved to increase Japan's defense spending and expand its security partnerships around the region. After a decade of decline, each of Abe's defense budgets since 2013 has modestly increased spending, now totaling roughly $50 billion per year. Next, in reforming postwar legal restrictions, such as the ban on arms exports or the ban on collective self-defense, Abe has attempted to offer Japan's support as a way to blunt some of China's growing military presence in Asia. Sales of maritime patrol vessels and airplanes to countries including Malaysia, Vietnam, and the Philippines are designed to help build up the capabilities of these nations in their territorial disputes with China over the Spratly and Paracel Islands. Similarly, Tokyo hoped to sell Australia its next generation of submarines, as well as provide India with amphibious search and rescue aircraft, though both of these plans ultimately fell through or were put on hold.[20]

Despite such setbacks, Japan has increased its security cooperation with a variety of nations in Asia, including in the South China Sea area. It has formally joined the Indo-US Malabar naval exercises and sent its largest helicopter carrier to the July 2017 exercise after three months of port visits in Southeast Asia. The Japanese coast guard remains actively engaged throughout the region and plans to set up a joint maritime safety organization with Southeast Asian coast guards to help them not only deal with piracy and natural disasters but also improve their ability to monitor and defend disputed territory in the South China Sea. Most recently, then Foreign Minister Taro Kono announced a $500 million